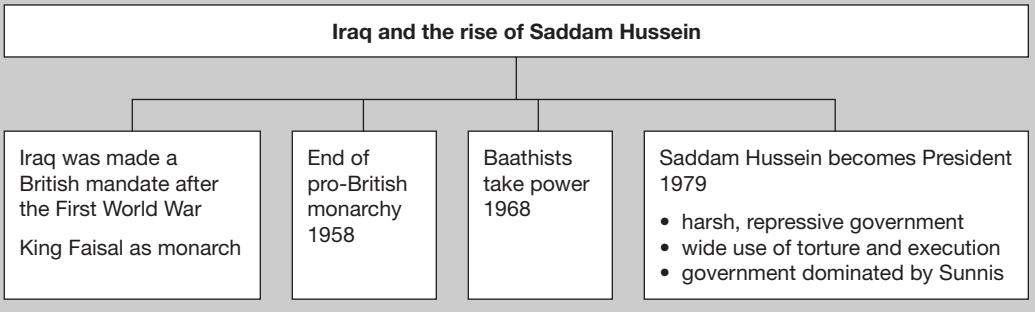
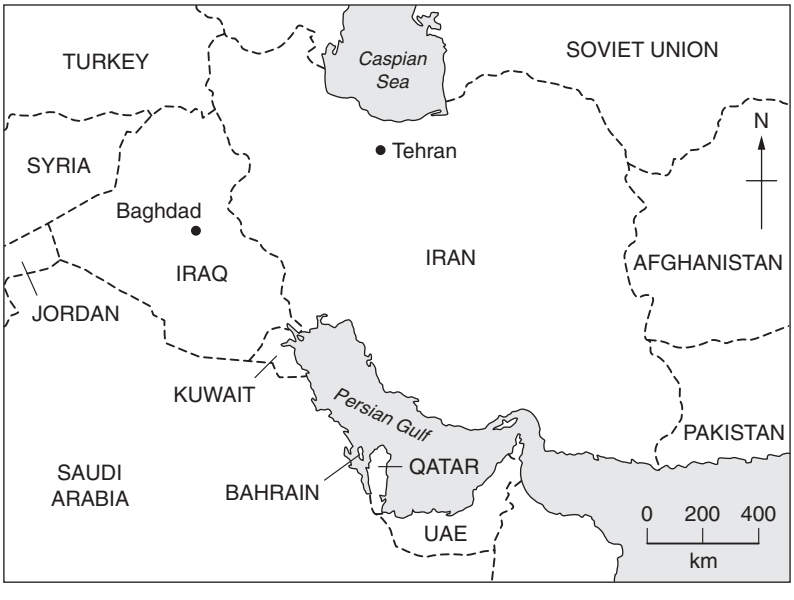
Saddam increasingly assumed the role of leader of the Arab world. His government became much more anti-Israeli in its propaganda: it opposed the Egypt–Israel peace treaty of 1979, accusing Egypt of betraying the Arab cause. Meanwhile Saddam himself was glorified. Statues of him were erected everywhere, his portraits hung in all public buildings and his birthday was made a national holiday. When a referendum was held on his presidency (undoubtedly rigged), 99 per cent voted in support. He was portrayed as a national hero, dedicated to his people.

Summary diagram: Iraq and the rise of Saddam Hussein



2 | The Iranian Revolution 1979

Iran used to be called Persia and, like Iraq, was home to one of the great civilisations of the world. Iran is three times as big as Iraq, in both land area and population. It has long borders with Iraq to its west and Russia to the north (see the map below). It is a Muslim country but it is different to its Arab neighbours in two major ways. First, its people are mostly non-Arab and do not speak Arabic. Secondly, it is mostly made up of Shia, not Sunni, Muslims.



Iran and its neighbours.